

Name: Raheek Muhammad Raiyan
ID:21301282
Sec:07

The Impact of Bangles in Our Culture

We might know about culture, but what really do the cultural components signify? While contemplating the core of a society, community, country, cultural elements or components or rituals emerge as the most significant manifestations of its identity and heritage. These components. These elements, whether intangible or tangible, represent the shared memories, values and customs that characterize a community. From exquisite traditional clothing to age-old customs, each element recounts the tale of a society's evolution over time. While choosing an original, unique, intricate cultural component, one must dive deep into the contemporary and historical fabric of a community to determine what truly defines its spirit. This might be a type of jewelry which passed down through the centuries, symbolizing connection and continuity, or a vibrant event that unites the people from all races of life demonstrating unity in diversity. By delving deep to examine such a cultural component, we can get the insights of the shared experiences and core values and norms that unites a community, know the soul of a society and deeper understanding of what makes it unique.

'Bangles' have been chosen as the cultural component that represents the community we live in for hundreds of years. Bangles have been a staple of many communities' cultural adornment or decoration schemes for many years. Particularly prominent in South Asian culture, these circular shaped ornaments worn around the wrist represent tradition, customs and identity, are more than mere ornamental pieces. The term "Bangle" comes from the word "Bangari", which means glass (Prashant, 2011). And in Bangla, it's called "churi". Bangles originated in ancient civilizations like the Indus Valley, where the archeological investigations and excavations have uncovered bangles fashioned of diverse elements like stone, shell, metal, terracotta etc. These ancient bangles are thought to have spiritual and protective meaning in addition to being served as adornments and social status symbols. Since then it has become an integral part of our culture or the culture of South Asia.

Over time, bangles craftsmanship has changed and evolved incorporating the cultural and aesthetic influences of many historical eras. In parts like Bengal, these bangles are seen as auspicious and have become the emblematic of the marital status mostly in the Hindu communities. In Hindu community, married women are not seen that much without the traditional Bengali bangle known as "*Shakha-Pola*" which is fashioned from the conch shell or the red coral and which represents wealth, happiness, marital bliss in marriages. Bangles might also have a personal meaning for the wearer.

Bangles serve a variety of purposes and to analyze these from the viewpoint of conflict theory, symbolic interactionism and functionalism, we should take into account their symbolic values, cultural meaning and the inequalities these represent. *Functionalist perspective* views the society and community as an intricate system where elements cooperate to preserve stability

and cohesion and solidarity (Boundless Sociology, 2020). This method focuses mainly on societal structures and examines from a macro-level perspective. In the **functionalist** point of view, the **manifestation** functions can consist of *cultural identity* as in Hindu culture, bangles can be the integral of wedding rituals whereas in Muslim culture, bangles are more of a symbol of tradition and femininity worn in different festivals. Aesthetic appeal, societal norms and rituals etc. Bangles can enhance the individual beauty and an important part of the traditional clothing or attire which is a part of *aesthetic appeal*. Bangles are basically a part of our *social rituals* used in different ceremonies worn by both Muslim and Hindu women. **Latent functions** may be composed of the economic impact and social bonding that might be created by the means of bangles. *Economic impact* as we see in both the Muslim and Hindu cultures, this industry related to bangles supports the craftspeople and the artisans who are responsible for these intricate ornaments and largely contributing to the local economies. Moreover, during all ceremonies and festivals, women sharing bangles fosters the sense of solidarity and community. In **dysfunction**, the economic burden and also the pressure of conformity are to be mentioned. As the mass expectation to wear and own elaborate bangles might put economical strain on one's family, mainly at the time of the wedding ceremonies, likewise the exertion of pressure on women for the adherence of traditional and societal norms might limit the individuality and personal expression of women.

On the other hand, the **conflict perspective** emphasizes on the material and political inequality of a community or society and critiques the system (Alan and James, 2015). It argues that the bangles are the causes of *social inequality* and the *gender roles* are also part of it. Because, the class distinction is the outcome as the material and type of bangles can denote economic status as richer women wear diamond or gold studded ones while the smallfolk wear metal or glass ones. *Gender roles*, as the custom of women wearing bangles in our culture upholds many expectations and gender roles, frequently forcing women to be in a position where they will have to adhere to social conventions about marital status and appearance. *Cultural hegemony* is the overshadowing of the minority or the local practices either because of regional influence or cultural homogenization or commercial influence which may cause unique cultural practices to gradually disappear and give away to homogenized culture shaped by dominant groups.

Symbolic interactionist perspective, which is based on the notion where mass people of a community make sense of a particular social world by the means of social interaction and communication through the exchange of language and symbols (Aksan et al., 2009). The symbolic values are the matter of prime discussion in this perspective. In Muslim culture, bangles are worn by women during the holy days and festivals to symbolize celebration, joy and the essence of the event. Moreover, *personal identity* and cultural identity is reflected while choosing the color, design of the bangles. While in Hindu community, the marital status of females depends on the bangles like "shakha-pola". *Auspiciousness* is, it is believed that the glass bangles are the bearer of good fortune and protection from evils. Bangles came to represent Saubhagya, or "the complete woman" (Prashant, 2011).

Cultural significance and symbolic values might vary culture to culture depending on their norms. Though for Muslim women, bangles are the means of happiness, festivity or ornaments

to beautify themselves, for the Hindu women, bangles are deeply intertwined with their rituals and customs. Glass bangles sound is thought as auspicious while breaking those is considered as bad omen. But in all cultures in bangles are symbolized as friendship, affection when the women share among themselves or are sent as gifts in functions. In an article, it is said that the bangles are far more than just a piece of jewelry (Anjali, 2023).

In conclusion, bangles as a cultural element, epitomize the customs, traditions and values of all the communities irrespective of religion and race. These represent theological value and profound culture along with being the symbol for beauty and marital status. We have analyzed how bangles serve a variety of purposes in a society while highlighting the social indifferences and by carrying symbolic meanings via the prisms of functionalist perspective, conflict perspective and symbolic perspective. By analyzing the impact on the minority customs, cultural hegemony, the comprehensive and proper understanding of their roles in our community. Therefore, bangles are the potent testament to cultural adaptation and continuity showcasing the complex relationship between modernity and traditions. We should be reminded of the significance of respecting and protecting our variety of cultural tapestries that enhance and prosper our community. Cultural symbols and components play an important role in expressing the essence of the definition of culture (Alexey, 2023).

References

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